Aquifer Open Study Notes (Profiles)

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This resource has been adapted into multiple languages, including English, Tok Pisin, Arabic (عربي), French (Français), Hindi (हिंदी), Indonesian (Bahasa Indonesia), Portuguese (Português), Russian (Русский), Spanish (Español), Swahili (Kiswahili), and Simplified Chinese (简体中文).

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Daniel

Daniel is a strong example of faith, wisdom, and endurance during difficult times and oppression. His life and prophecies show that God is in control and will ultimately win, even when evil seems powerful.

Daniel belonged to Judah's royal family when the Babylonian army first attacked Jerusalem in 605 BC (Daniel 1:3). He was taken to Babylon with Azariah, Hananiah, and Mishael. King Nebuchadnezzar trained these young men, along with others, to serve in his expanding empire. Daniel and his friends were the smartest and healthiest students, so they held important positions in Nebuchadnezzar's court.

Daniel worked in the court for nearly seventy years (see Daniel 1:21). He quickly gained a reputation for intelligence and complete loyalty to God. When Nebuchadnezzar had a troubling dream, God revealed its meaning to Daniel, who explained it to the king (Daniel 2). Later, Daniel interpreted a second dream about the king's pride (Daniel 4). Daniel urged Nebuchadnezzar to repent, but he did not. As a result, Nebuchadnezzar temporarily lost his sanity (Daniel 4:28–37).

Daniel always showed respect to the Babylonian king. Nebuchadnezzar respected Daniel highly because of his good character and behavior. This led Nebuchadnezzar to worship the Lord, although not exclusively. Daniel's faithfulness and wisdom inspire readers in hostile cultures today.

Later, Belshazzar, the vice-regent of Babylon, used the sacred vessels from the Jerusalem Temple disrespectfully during a banquet in 539 BC. Suddenly, a disembodied hand wrote the words "Mene, Mene, Tekel, and Parsin" on the palace wall. Daniel interpreted these words as predicting Babylon's imminent end. That same night, Persians captured the capital and killed Belshazzar (Daniel 5:1–31).

In 539 BC, under Darius the Mede, Daniel became an administrator of the kingdom (Daniel 6:2). Daniel's effective management angered his political enemies. They convinced Darius to issue a decree that banned worship of anyone except the king, with the punishment of being thrown into a lions' den. To maintain his religious beliefs, Daniel broke the law, but he was miraculously unharmed by the lions. Afterward, he returned to his position (Daniel 6:17–28). Daniel's later visions are from around this time (Daniel 10:1, 4).

Daniel's prophecies are hard to understand in detail, but their message is clear: Evil forces are in power now, but God is in control and will save his people. Jesus and New Testament authors cited Daniel, often using his imagery when discussing the end times (for example, compare Daniel 7:1–9 and Revelation 13:1–10; Daniel 7:13 and Revelation 1:7; Daniel 9:27 and Matthew 24:15). Daniel was certain that God Most High would win.

Passages for Further Study

Ezekiel 14:14, 20; 28:3; Daniel 1:1–12:13; Matthew 24:15

David

David is one of the most important people in the Bible. His time as king was a very special period in God's plan for Israel. The things David did as king had a great and lasting effect on Israel's future.

David was born in Bethlehem as Jesse's youngest son. His family history goes back to Judah (Ruth 4:18–22; 1 Chronicles 2:3–15; Matthew 1:3–6; Luke 3:31–33). When he was born, the Jebusites occupied Jerusalem, and many parts of the promised land were still under foreign control, especially by the Philistines. God would use David to finish conquering the land.

As a young man, David was a simple shepherd, caring for his father's sheep (1 Samuel 16:11; 17:14–15). His life changed unexpectedly when the prophet Samuel visited Jesse and anointed David as the future king of Israel. However, David did not become king through a coup or assassination. Instead, he served King Saul faithfully. David first joined Saul's service as a musician, playing songs that calmed Saul's troubled mind (1 Samuel 16:14–23). This role foreshadowed David's work as the composer of many psalms. Young David also helped Saul by famously defeating the Philistine champion Goliath in single combat (1 Samuel 17:32–51). This victory foreshadowed David's future as a successful military leader.

David was loyal, but Saul became very suspicious of him. So, David had to flee. He escaped with help from Saul's children, Jonathan and Michal. David led a kingdom in exile with an army of six hundred men. The prophet Gad and the priest Abiathar were with him, offering guidance from the Lord.

God's patience with Saul eventually ended, and Saul died in battle. Even then, David found it difficult to become the ruler of all Israel. The tribe of Judah quickly made him their king, but the northern tribes initially chose Ishbosheth, Saul's son, as their leader. Ishbosheth was weak and ineffective; he remained in power only because of his father's military leader,

Abner. However, Ishbosheth insulted Abner, so the general helped transfer the kingdom to David.

As king of a united Israel, David strengthened the kingdom. He and his men captured Jerusalem from the Jebusites and made it his capital. He forced the last of the Philistines to leave the land. David then brought the ark of the covenant into Jerusalem. He wanted to build a permanent temple for God in Jerusalem to replace the tabernacle. God denied this wish but showed love for David by making a covenant (special agreement) with him, establishing his descendants as a family of kings (2 Samuel 7).

David's life soon worsened (see 2 Samuel 11–12). When he should have been with his army, he stayed on the palace roof. He saw a beautiful woman named Bathsheba bathing and desired her. So, like other powerful kings of that time who took whatever they wanted, he took Bathsheba. She became pregnant, and his attempt to hide his adultery failed. David was desperate, so he had her husband, Uriah, killed. However, even a great king like David cannot hide secrets from God. God sent his prophet Nathan to confront David. David was sorry for what he had done (see Psalms 32, 51). But his actions affected his family and his reign.

From then on, David's family began to have many problems and conflicts. David's son Amnon raped his half-sister Tamar (2 Samuel 13:1–14). Her brother Absalom then murdered Amnon (2 Samuel 13:20–29). Absalom later started a civil war as he tried to become king instead of his father (2 Samuel 15–18). Another son, Adonijah, tried to become king instead of David by declaring himself king while his father was still alive (1 Kings 1:5–10). But David gathered enough strength to ensure that Solomon would be king after him (1 Kings 1:28–40). When David died, Solomon became king. Solomon was the first of many kings from David's family (as promised in 2 Samuel 7).

Most of the kings who came after David were not as good at leading as he was. His descendants rarely led the nation to worship God faithfully. The united kingdom of Israel did not last beyond Solomon. In the following centuries, David's descendants ruled only Judah in the south. Eventually, the kingdom of Judah was destroyed. A descendant of David never again ruled as king in Israel.

What about the promise to David that "your throne will be secure forever" (2 Samuel 7:16)? The New Testament refers to Jesus. He was a descendant of David, and God declared him the Christ, or Messiah—the anointed king (see Matthew 1:1; 9:27; 12:23; Mark 10:47–48; 11:10; 12:35–37; Luke 18:38–39; 20:41–44; John 7:42; Revelation 5:5; 22:16). David's life and rule foreshadow the messianic reign of Jesus Christ, which will last forever (see Luke 1:32–33; Revelation 11:15).

Passages for Further Study

Ruth 4:13–22; 1 Samuel 16:1–17:58; 18:1–27:12; 29:1–30:31; 2 Samuel 1:1–24:25; 1 Kings 1:1–2:12; 1 Chronicles 11:1–29:30; Psalms 1–32, 34–41, 51–71, 86, 91–110, 122, 124, 131, 133, 138–145; Matthew 1:1; 9:27; 22:41–46; Mark 12:35–37; Luke 20:41–44; John 7:40–44; Acts 2:22–37; 13:20–43; Romans 1:3; Revelation 22:16

Deborah

The prophet Deborah was one of the early judges of Israel. She was a woman of integrity and devotion to the Lord. As a prophet, she received divine messages. As a judge, she settled legal disputes. People often called her "a mother in Israel" (see Judges 5:7).

During Deborah's time, people were doing more wrong things. They stopped following God's ways, and the tribes of Israel were not united. Israel was doing "evil in the sight of the LORD" (Judges 4:1). So, God handed Israel over to an oppressor, Jabin of Canaan. Once more, Israel cried out to the Lord for help (Judges 4:3).

God called Barak to fight Sisera, the commander of Jabin's army, through Deborah. However, Barak was not enthusiastic or brave. He insisted that Deborah accompany him. Deborah agreed but warned that a woman would receive the glory for the victory, not Barak. This came true when Barak defeated Sisera and his army, but Jael, the woman who killed Sisera, received the glory. Barak showed little courage or leadership. This was very different from the courage and leadership of Deborah and Jael. Deborah's actions led to forty years of peace for Israel (Judges 5:31).

Passages for Further Study

Judges 4:1–5:31